

Chapter 130-1

Liang Shi once had a wish—to have lots and lots of love.

That was a line from a movie she had watched many years ago, and she often quoted it.

In everyone's eyes, she was Qiu Zimin's most beloved daughter.

But love spoken a thousand, ten thousand times from the mouth isn't love.

Real love is something you can feel—like from her eldest brother.

But her eldest brother was too busy back then. He was being groomed as the primary heir of the Liang family, and there were extremely high demands on him in terms of both skills and character.

So back then, he not only had heavy coursework but also all sorts of social etiquette classes.

The time he could spare for Liang Shi was limited.

The days spent playing with her eldest brother were very happy—those were times when she could feel love.

That's why she could clearly sense that the "love" Qiu Zimin gave her was distorted.

Qiu Zimin only "loved" her in front of others.

Behind closed doors, it was always contempt and disgust.

As for her father, he was just a background decoration, completely indifferent to her.

It was precisely because she had her eldest brother as a comparison that she knew what she received from Qiu Zimin was all an illusion.

So she wanted lots and lots of love.

She didn't want to be sent to Yang Jiani by Qiu Zimin, and she didn't want to keep seeing Qiu Zimin's disgusted gaze.

As a young child, she didn't even understand why Qiu Zimin had to hate her.

She clearly liked... children very much.

Whether it was her eldest brother or second brother, she was always strict yet loving with them. Only toward her was it different.

The lots of love she wanted back then was nothing more than gaining some warmth in that cold, icy home.

After she came to this world, although she didn't have parents, her grandparents gave her enough love.

They depended on each other for survival. Even though life was poor, there was enough love.

But the original owner had borne Qiu Zimin's "revenge" in her place, becoming cynical and irritable.

The system had once said that she and the original owner were a correction—a restoration of normal order.

Then who had caused the change in order?

In other words, who had swapped the fates of the two of them?

If her guess was correct, what was the original owner's wish?

And Qi Jiao had died in despair in that world, yet was reborn in this world.

It was as if it were a mirror world.

Everything she hadn't possessed in that world was made up for in this world.

A happy family. Family members who doted on her.

But correspondingly, she had also lost some things.

Such as memories. Such as intelligence.

The original Qi Jiao was very smart—at such a young age, she already knew how to write her diary in Morse code.

But the Qi Jiao in this world, because of the high fever she had before the zhongkao, ended up with very poor grades.

She clearly wasn't that old, yet she said she had a goldfish brain and was always forgetting things.

And then there was Sun Chengcheng.

After returning, Liang Shi also learned about Sun Chengcheng's current situation.

Liang Shi also still remembered the times when Sun Chengcheng would post on Weibo for promotional purposes in that world. In the timelines of these two worlds, there were many overlapping points.

Sun Chengcheng only became connected to that world after her career here hit rock bottom and she became the target of public criticism in the entertainment industry.

But for Sun Chengcheng, she could travel back and forth between the two worlds.

As if she were on a higher level.

Hers was a wish come true, Qi Jiao's was a mirror world, Sun Chengcheng's was traveling through time and space...

There seemed to be commonalities, yet there also seemed to be not quite so many commonalities.

After carefully sorting through everything, Liang Shi fell into deep thought again.

Before she could think of anything, she heard Xiao Bai shout: "Sister Liang, we're here!"

Liang Shi was startled into a shiver, then came back to her senses.

Xiao Bai muttered: "Thinking about your girlfriend again? You're so absent-minded."

Liang Shi raised her hand and pressed on the space between her eyebrows. Too many threads were tangled together in her mind, as if she had just experienced a storm.

She shook her head: "Just thinking about some things."

Before getting out of the car, Liang Shi reminded Wang Zhaozhao: "Sister Wang, about the press conference... make it as soon as possible."

Wang Zhaozhao nodded coolly: "Got it. I'll go negotiate."

Actually, in this era, press conferences were already outdated.

Livestreaming was the fastest way.

But livestreams could only be seen by fans—only by people who liked her.

There were also many "passersby."¹

Most importantly, Liang Shi wanted to bid farewell to this industry she deeply loved in a proper manner.

She had once bloomed on the big screen, and in the end, she would also wither in front of the camera.

Xiao Bai kept saying it was a pity, but Liang Shi said: "Once you've decided, there's nothing to feel sorry about. There are too many choices and possibilities in life."

1. Passersby (路人): In Chinese internet/entertainment terminology, "passersby" refers to people who are neither fans nor haters of a celebrity—they're neutral observers or the general public who may have casual opinions but aren't invested followers. ⇐

Chapter 130-2

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Liang Shi had already walked to the entrance of the residential complex, but before going in, she took a turn and went to the "Deep Sea Sleepless" flower shop.

When she pushed open the door and entered, there was still a customer in the flower shop. Qi Jiao was making recommendations for her.

The customer bought a bouquet of tulips. When leaving, she glanced at Liang Shi several times as she passed by. She had already pushed open the door with one foot stepping out, but then came back in and asked in surprise: "You're Liang Shi, right?"

Liang Shi nodded. "Hello."

"Ahhhh! It really is you." The other person's face was full of excitement. "I really like your drama Mo Huan."¹

Being able to name one of her works made Liang Shi feel gratified.

The other person took out the card from the tulips she had just bought. "Can you write a blessing for me? And sign your name too."

Liang Shi took the card and nodded in agreement.

The other person had no requirements for the blessing, telling her to write whatever she wanted. She only mentioned that her best friend also really liked Liang Shi, and when she learned about Liang Shi's incident a while ago, she lost ten jin² from the stress.

Liang Shi thought for a moment and wrote: [May everything go as you wish, and may you always remain sincere.]

To express her gratitude, the other person bought another bouquet of baby's breath from Qi Jiao and gave it to Liang Shi.

"Your Mo Huan accompanied me through so many unforgettable days." The other person said, "I hope that in the future, you can be like Chen Chao from Mo Huan—moving forward with unwavering determination, not being swayed by rumors."

After she left, Liang Shi stared at the baby's breath in her hands, still somewhat dazed.

Had she just met a very sincere fan?

Not long ago, she had given Xu Qingzhu a bouquet of baby's breath.

Mm, she was thinking about Xu Qingzhu again.

After that girl left, only Liang Shi and Qi Jiao remained in the shop.

Qi Jiao was single-mindedly arranging her flowers. Only after she finished did she ask Liang Shi: "Have you decided what you want to buy?"

"I'm not buying flowers." Liang Shi said.

Qi Jiao was surprised. "Hm?"

Liang Shi held the bouquet of baby's breath and said: "I came to see you."

Qi Jiao: "..."

Liang Shi found a chair and sat down. Facing Qi Jiao's surprise, she smiled: "It's boring staying home alone, so I came out to find someone to chat with. Do you mind?"

Qi Jiao's expression changed from puzzlement to joy. She shook her head: "I don't mind."

As she spoke, she took out a bunch of snacks from the cabinet and placed them in front of Liang Shi.

"Anyway, I don't have many customers here. If you're willing, feel free to come by often." Qi Jiao said, "Have some snacks."

"Why do you always carry candy with you?" Liang Shi asked.

Qi Jiao shook her head: "I don't know. It's just a habit."

After a while, she added: "Maybe it's because I had low blood sugar when I was little, so my mom would always put candy in my school bag. I would always take it out and share it with the other kids."

Liang Shi nodded: "You're really kind-hearted."

On an ordinary, unremarkable morning, Liang Shi and Qi Jiao sat in the flower shop, chatting casually.

When Liang Shi stood up to leave, Qi Jiao hesitantly asked: "Oh right, that Chen Mian you mentioned... is she a painter?"

Liang Shi hesitated, changing the "Did you remember?" that was already on the tip of her tongue to "Why do you say that?"

A trace of confusion flashed in Qi Jiao's eyes. "I don't know either, but my intuition tells me she should be a painter."

She said: "The name just sounds very artistic."

Liang Shi smiled slightly: "Not everyone with an artistic name becomes a painter."

Qi Jiao looked dazed. "Huh?"

Liang Shi answered with certainty: "But Chen Mian is."

"Qi Jiao." Liang Shi called her name. "Live well."

Liang Shi's tone was gentle, that pleasant voice carrying a tender, lingering quality.

It sounded like a voice flowing out from an old record.

Qi Jiao was stunned for a moment, then waved at her. "Mèimei,³ you live well too."

This long-missed form of address instantly pulled Liang Shi back to her childhood.

Liang Shi slowly broke into a smile. "I will."

—I will find Xu Qingzhu and live well.

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1. Mo Huan (至歡): The title of the drama Liang Shi acted in. The characters 至歡 can be interpreted as "utmost joy" or "to the point of happiness." ↵
 2. Jin (斤): A Chinese unit of weight. One jin equals 500 grams or approximately 1.1 pounds. Ten jin would be about 5 kilograms or 11 pounds. ↵
 3. Mèimei (妹妹): Meaning "younger sister" in Chinese. It's an affectionate term used for younger females, not necessarily blood-related. This was how Qi Jiao used to address young Liang Shi when they were children, making this moment emotionally significant. ↵

Chapter 130-3

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Liang Shi received Xu Qingzhu's reply from Sun Chengcheng: Thank you for the concern. Everything is well.

Just eight simple characters.

But Liang Shi knew—Xu Qingzhu understood.

After receiving this reply, Liang Shi's heart calmed down.

She also didn't go looking for Sun Chengcheng to deliver messages anymore. Doing it too often would make it easy for Sun Chengcheng to notice something was off.

Liang Shi made up some random excuse to brush Sun Chengcheng off.

Then, on a clear and sunny Saturday, she held a press conference.

Her Weibo hadn't been updated in a long time, and Sister Wang had already closed the comments section.

The last Weibo post was: Have retired. Don't miss me.

At that time, she had been unconscious. The doctors said she had become a vegetative patient, and Sister Wang had no choice but to release a retirement statement.

After Liang Shi came back, she naturally learned about all of this.

After she fell into a coma, she had been well-loved by this world.

Holding press conferences was something celebrities commonly did over twenty years ago. In recent years, this form of event had almost become extinct in the entertainment industry.

When multiple reporters received the notice, they were all confused. But as soon as they heard it was Liang Shi, they knew it was big news.

Although they didn't know what it was about, many media outlets sent people.

Liang Shi appeared at the press conference wearing a white shirt and a light-colored suit jacket. The moment she showed her face, the cameras below kept clicking away.

She had thought about making a clarification long ago. Even if she couldn't make the whole world hear it, she had at least said it to herself.

Including the "Clarification" document on her phone that she had written when she felt indignant.

So she didn't bring any documents. Facing the cameras, she calmly and naturally recounted her journey in the entertainment industry over the years. Then she shifted the topic to the previous "scandal" with Sun Chengcheng.

She frankly admitted to the cameras: "Yes, I like girls, but I don't think this is something that should be used to attack me. Yes, I indeed never attended university, but I have never stopped learning."

"As for Sun Chengcheng, I never did anything to her that could be criticized. It was purely fabricated." After saying this, Liang Shi played an audio recording.

It was what Sun Chengcheng had said when Liang Shi went to her home that day and got her to talk.

Sun Chengcheng's voice was shrill, filled with endless hatred.

She had retorted: "Where am I worse than you?"

She had screamed hoarsely: "I don't want to see you doing so well."

"What people do—" After the recording finished playing, before the reporters could react, Liang Shi said: "—heaven sees.¹ I'm very grateful to the friends who spoke up for me when I was seriously ill, and thank you to the fans who were willing to believe in me. But now I might have to disappoint you all."

"I announce that starting today, I am retiring from the entertainment industry indefinitely." Liang Shi smiled at the cameras. "I will no longer appear on any public platform, including livestream sales and the like. Public accounts such as Weibo will also be deactivated starting today."

The audience below erupted in commotion.

But Liang Shi smiled contentedly: "May we always live under the sunlight."

1. What people do, heaven sees (人在做，天在看): A Chinese proverb meaning that even if no one else sees your actions, the heavens are always watching. It implies that good and bad deeds will eventually be rewarded or punished accordingly—karma, in a sense. ⇐

Chapter 130-4

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On the way back, Xiao Bai was chattering away like a magpie.

From her mouth, one could constantly hear comments from online.

Most were lamenting Liang Shi's retirement from the industry, though many also expressed their blessings.

There was even a bold artist who directly rode Liang Shi's wave to officially announce her relationship with a same-sex partner.

Liang Shi used her account that hadn't been deactivated yet to comment on and like her post.

Then she chose to deactivate the account.

She also sent a message to that artist on WeChat: [Wishing you forever and always.]¹

The weather was beautiful. The sun shone warmly on the earth, making people feel lazy.

The peach blossoms outside had just bloomed, clustered on the branches, a sight that lifted one's spirits.

After getting out of the car, Liang Shi planned to go home, but she ran into Qi Jiao at the entrance of the residential complex.

Qi Jiao had both hands behind her back. When she saw Liang Shi, she smiled and walked over.

"Congratulations on becoming an ordinary person again." Qi Jiao said as she brought out a bunch of irises from behind her back.

The flower language of irises is freedom.

Qi Jiao said: "I saw what you said online. Thank you for speaking up for our community."

Liang Shi:

Qi Jiao smiled slightly. "Actually... I also like girls."

"But don't misunderstand. I'm not giving you flowers because I like you. It's also not..." Qi Jiao was momentarily at a loss for words. After a long while, she knocked on her own head and said: "This wooden head of mine. It's just... I've always seen you as a younger sister."

Liang Shi chuckled softly: "Is that so?"

Qi Jiao nodded: "Of course. Although I like girls, I... haven't dated yet. My family is actually quite open-minded. They think as long as I'm happy, that's fine. But from childhood until now, it's always been boys chasing me. I find them scary to look at."

Liang Shi and Qi Jiao stood by the roadside and chatted for a while. Then they heard someone calling Qi Jiao's name.

The two of them turned around together and saw a married couple walking toward them, along with a slightly roguish-looking man and a woman dressed in a professional elite style.

Qi Jiao immediately beamed with joy and practically jogged over. "Dad, Mom, Gē, Jiě!"

Liang Shi watched their family standing together and felt quite gratified.

At noon, she even had a meal with Qi Jiao's family. Probably because Qi Jiao's whole family knew about Qi Jiao's orientation, the looks they gave Liang Shi weren't very friendly—despite Qi Jiao's repeated insistence that Liang Shi was just an ordinary friend.

Liang Shi still ended up being made to drink quite a bit of alcohol.

In the afternoon, back at home, she scrolled through the comments online. They were mixed—some praising, some criticizing.

As evening approached, the city started raining again.

The irises Qi Jiao gave her were placed in a vase. The peach blossoms Liang Shi had picked on her way back in the afternoon lay quietly on the coffee table.

Liang Shi curled up on the sofa watching TV—an old movie she had seen many times.

The pitter-patter of rain fell on the windows, connecting into streaks of water.

This house used to be the place she found most comfortable. No matter how noisy it was outside, she could build a warm little world by herself.

But now the house felt very empty.

Even with the movie playing, it still felt quiet.

Liang Shi took out a piece of paper again to sort through those clues.

She and the original owner had been artificially swapped, so their previous swap was a correction—a restoration of order. The trigger was that she was down on her luck here, while the original owner wanted to harm others over there.

Qi Jiao was kind by nature but lived a painful life, so it was equivalent to giving her a chance at rebirth.

As for Sun Chengcheng, she had gained the ability to travel back and forth. She couldn't stay in utopia forever.

She still had to spend most of her time here, and here caused her pain.

What allowed her to temporarily escape from the pain was the other world. But without comparison, there's no harm—the beauty of the other world made her only want to indulge in it. So in the real world, she became increasingly depressed, living an exceptionally miserable life.

Just like what Liang Shi saw when she went there that day.

—So this was very likely some kind of balancing mechanism.

Liang Shi felt like she had figured out some clues. Suddenly, her mind felt like it was being pricked by needles, and a strange crackling sound of static came through: "Crackle crackle..."

Liang Shi pressed on her temples. Those static sounds mixed with strange mechanical tones kept coming through.

[Connecting... crackle...]

[Repairing... crackle... repair in progress... crackle...]

A few seconds later, her mind returned to calm. The mechanical voice unique to that damned system came through: [Phew! Finally fixed! Sorry, Host. Due to atmospheric interference that day causing space-time disruption, the program was damaged, resulting in a deviation during transmission.]

[But Host, you're really smart~ You actually figured out the balancing mechanism of the plane worlds. Applause for you.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Facing the system, Liang Shi had only four words: "Send me back."

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1. Wishing you forever and always (祝久久): A blessing playing on the word "久" (jiǔ), which means "long/forever" and sounds like the number nine (九). "久久" literally means "for a long, long time" and is commonly used in blessings to wish someone lasting happiness, especially in relationships. ⇐